

Previously skeptical opponents of the Republicans now accepted that “The Slave Power is the same in Missouri as it is in Washington.” These violent acts seemed to prove Republican assertions of Southern “Slave Power” and its threat to white men, whether they were laborers, settlers, or senators.

The failure of the president, the Congress, and the courts to render justice as demanded by an enraged Northern public added indignity to a sense of imminent danger. The Republican Party took advantage of this and used an extensive network of editors, ministers, and party workers to print and distribute a vast amount of political propaganda. The Southern press retaliated. In May 1856, the *Enquirer* in Richmond, Virginia, urged that “vulgar abolitionists ... must be lashed into submission.” Later that year, an Alabama editor fumed, “Free society, we sicken at the name ... a conglomeration of greasy mechanics, filthy operatives, small-fisted farmers, and moonstruck theorists ... hardly fit for association with a Southern gentleman’s body servant.” Such provocative statements only served to remind Northerners that Republicans stood ready to defend their interests against the South.

Rapidly growing support

Heated debates and political violence erupted over what party was fit to rule. The rapid spread of anger at Southern attitudes about slavery enabled the Republican Party to attract both abolitionists and moderates willing to vote against Southern institutions and culture.

The aim of stopping the expansion of slavery unified the Republican Party. Enslavers cringed at this political dogma, given the increase of populations in the North and West. Southerners feared losing the political balance in Congress, which protected their interests. They knew that slavery ultimately would be subjected to the will of the majority.

For a party that had been founded as recently as 1854, the Republicans achieved a remarkable result in their first presidential election. Their candidate John C. Frémont carried 11 states to